have not been able to derive optimum benefits of these bonds. The political turbulence owes its origin to the king dismissing the government, and declaring a state of emergency on 1 February 2005. This event took place when I had just taken over as the army chief, and relations between the two neighbours nosedived. India's view was that the action taken by the king was violative of the constitution of Nepal. As a result, regrettably, I could not visit that country to receive the honorary rank of general in the Nepal army. In fact, in the wake of this action, there was a lot of bloodshed and violence perpetrated by the Maoists. The Nepalese army came down heavily on the Maoists, but suffered a fair number of casualties too. Finally, when the elections were held, King Gyanendra Shah was forced to step down and the monarchy was abolished. During this extremely turbulent period, the Nepalese army chief, General Ruk Mangad Katuwal, spoke to me on a few occasions and sought my advice. I recall advising him to follow our example of being an apolitical, secular and professional force doing the assigned charter of duties as per the Constitution, and taking orders from the democratically elected government.

Gorkha ex-servicemen of the Indian Army are disbursed their pensions running into several million rupees every month, through the Indian army-administered pension offices in various parts of Nepal, including mobile pension offices. For these veterans and their families, we have also been providing medical cover by sending teams into various parts of Nepal. These links make relations between our two countries special. But there is considerable scope to make them stronger by leveraging the bonds and ties of sacrifices made by our soldiers together for more than a century. The relationship is yet to achieve the solidity that should be there. There have been needless misunderstandings in the past, as some influential sections of their society have perceived us to be interfering in their internal affairs. Today, our positive approach towards the transition of Nepal to a democratic and progressive entity and help in its development under the aegis of Indo-Nepal economic programme is being welcomed by the people.